

Wondering if losing the spark means you're falling out of love

8 findings · 11-step checklist · 5 sources · cheatgrid.com

The early rush fading doesn't mean the love went with it. Commitment holds a long relationship together, along with how generously you see your partner, more than how exciting an ordinary Tuesday feels.

THE GOAL

You're checking whether you're both still in this and still doing the small things. Say a specific thank you today for something your partner actually did.

CHECKLIST

The moment you notice, again, that this feels flat compared to how it used to, and the thought that you're falling out of love shows up.

- ☐ Put a name to the one specific thing that felt different just now, not "everything about us."
- ☐ If you're picking a fight or going quiet instead of saying what's actually going on, choose the saying instead, even if it feels smaller.
- ☐ Bring to mind one specific thing your partner did for you in the last day or two, however small.
- ☐ **Say a specific thank you** to them today for something they did, like "thank you for grabbing that, it helped."
- ☐ Do one small affectionate thing you used to do without being asked, like making their coffee or touching their back.
- ☐ Name one thing you still admire about them, the way you would have a year ago.
- ☐ Tell them plainly that you're still in this, in your own words, like "I'm not going anywhere, this is just a flat patch."
- ☐ Pick one new, slightly unpredictable thing to try together (a class, a new area, a short trip) and **set a day** for it this week.
- ☐ If this keeps happening on ordinary days with no argument in sight, make trying something new together a repeating habit, not a one-off.
- ☐ Write down, somewhere you'll see it again later, the one thing you noticed today and the one thing you did about it.
- ☐ Pick a real point to check back in on this, like two weeks from now, rather than deciding anything today.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** Noticing more flaws than good in them **is not neutral**. How generously you see them shapes whether you stay together.
- 2** Your partner's belief in your commitment mattered more for whether the relationship lasted than anything else researchers measured.
- 3** The fading itself doesn't mean love is basically gone. Newlyweds studied a year into marriage still felt a fairly strong amount of love, even once the earliest rush had faded.

Your part in what's happening

WATCH

Noticing more flaws than good in them **is not neutral**. How generously you see them shapes whether you stay together.

Seeing their good side generously seems to carry couples through ordinary doubts and conflict instead of letting those doubts take over. [Source 5](#)

DO

Naming something small they did for you still matters, even now. In daily reports from couples, feeling grateful for a partner's thoughtful action was followed by feeling more connected and satisfied the very next day, for both of them.

Gratitude lifted both the giver's and the receiver's own sense of connection by about the same amount. [Source 4](#)

What actually decides whether this lasts

KNOW

Your partner's belief in your commitment mattered more for whether the relationship lasted than anything else researchers measured.

An international team of researchers testing many possible predictors of relationship success found this belief **mattered more than anything else they measured**. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Feeling different lately is rarely about who your partner has become. Their own personality barely explained how satisfied you'd feel.

Even with detailed measures of who each partner is, that barely explained how satisfied the other partner turned out to be. [Source 1](#)

How much decline is normal

KNOW

The fading itself doesn't mean love is basically gone. Newlyweds studied a year into marriage still felt a fairly strong amount of love, even once the earliest rush had faded.

The measured decline was small on their scale, and the authors themselves call love in the second year surprisingly high, not a big loss. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

The easy, comfortable side fades too. Affection faded almost as much as passion did in tracked couples.

Newlyweds re-interviewed about a year later showed this same pattern, not only couples married for years. [Source 2](#)

What keeps the everyday feeling from draining away

DO

Routine time together only goes so far on its own. In several experiments, couples who tried something new and exciting together, even briefly, rated it higher afterward than couples who spent the same time on something familiar.

The lift came specifically from the newness and mild thrill of the activity, apart from the time spent or the company itself. [Source 3](#)

WATCH

The flat, bored feeling itself matters. In tracked couples, boredom kept lowering how satisfied they felt even beyond what their level of exciting shared activity could explain.

Boredom kept explaining the drop even after researchers accounted for how much exciting time couples spent together. [Source 3](#)

Sources

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5. [https://faculty.washington.edu/jdb/345/345%20Articles/Chapter%2011%20Murray%20et%20al.%20\(1996\).pdf](https://faculty.washington.edu/jdb/345/345%20Articles/Chapter%2011%20Murray%20et%20al.%20(1996).pdf)

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Keeping a long relationship good at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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